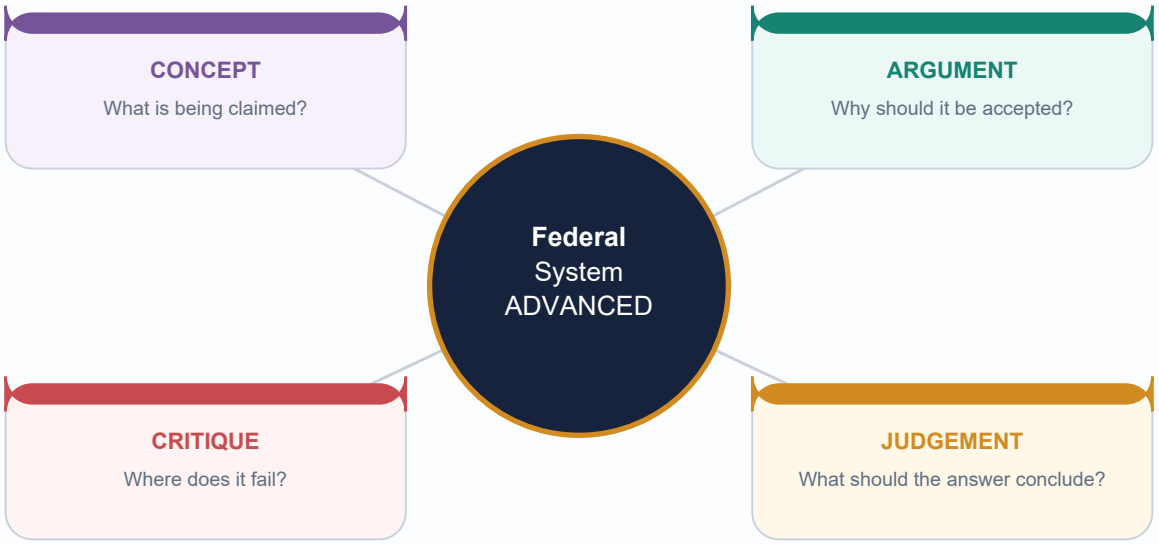
UPSC INDIAN POLITY

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE Deep-Learning Visual Notes

Indian Polity · GS Paper II · Prelims + Mains
Layer 1: Basic foundation · Layer 2: Advanced constitutional and exam depth
Sources: Federal-System.md + 12_Federal-System.md
Learning cards: 47



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Foundation · Core Foundation

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Subject: Polity · **Tier:** Basic (foundation) · **GS Paper:** GS-II

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE FOUNDATION: RECALL MAP

Core Foundation

V

Dimension 1 Subject: Polity · Tier: Basic (foundation) · GS Paper: GS-II	**Dimension 2** Grounded in: Laxmikant Ch. 13. □ = from book · □□ = inference · □ = current affairs.
Dimension 3 Advanced: optional deeper detail in advanced/12Federal-System.md — not required for any mark.	

STATIC THEORY

- **Grounded in:** Laxmikant Ch. 13. □ = from book · □□ = inference · □ = current affairs.

- *Advanced: optional deeper detail in advanced/12_Federal-System.md — not required for any mark.*

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Grounded in: Laxmikant Ch. 13. = from book · □□ = inference · □ = current affairs.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Core Foundation

HIGH

Foundation · Snapshot

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Item	Fact
□ Word "Federation" in Constitution	**Never used** — Art 1 says **"Union of States"**
□ Model borrowed from	**Canada** (strong centre), NOT USA
□ Formed by	**Disintegration** ("holding together")
□ Reasons	Large **size** + socio-cultural **diversity**
□ 7th Schedule lists	Standard examination counts: Union **(100)**, State **(61)**, Concurrent **(52)**; residuary → **Centre**. Omitted and inserted entry numbers can produce different literal counts.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Snapshot

HIGH

Foundation · Core idea

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Powers are **divided by the Constitution itself** between Centre & states (federal), but the balance is deliberately **tilted toward the Union**. Hence India is a **constitutionally federal, Union-weighted** system; “quasi-federal” is a scholarly characterisation, not a substitute for the constitutional test or *Bommai*.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Powers are **divided by the Constitution itself** between Centre & states (federal), but the balance is deliberately **tilted toward the Union**. Hence India is a **constitutionally federal, Union-weighted** system; “quasi-federal” is a scholarly characterisation, not a substitute for the constitutional test or *Bommai*.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Core idea

HIGH

Foundation · 7 Federal features

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Mnemonic: "Dual Writing Divides Supreme Rigid Independent Bicameral" = **D**ual polity ·

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

7 FEDERAL FEATURES: RECALL MAP

7 Federal features

V

Dimension 1 Mnemonic: "Dual Writing Divides Supreme Rigid Independent Bicameral" = Dual polity ·	**Dimension 2** Written Constitution · Division of powers · Supremacy of Constitution · Rigidity ·
Dimension 3 Independent judiciary · Bicameralism.	

STATIC THEORY

- **W**ritten Constitution · **D**ivision of powers · **S**upremacy of Constitution · **R**igidity ·

- **I**ndependent judiciary · **B**icameralism.

MEMORY HOOK

Mnemonic: "Dual Writing Divides Supreme Rigid Independent Bicameral" = Dual polity ·

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ 7 Federal features

HIGH

Foundation · Unitary features (the 14) — high-yield

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Strong Centre · destructible states · single Constitution · flexibility · unequal RS seats · emergency provisions · single citizenship · integrated judiciary · All-India Services · integrated audit (CAG) · Parliament over State List (Art 249) · centrally appointed Governor · integrated ECI · President's power over reserved State bills.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Strong Centre · destructible states · single Constitution · flexibility · unequal RS seats · emergency provisions · single citizenship · integrated judiciary · All-India Services · integrated audit (CAG) · Parliament over State List (Art 249) · centrally appointed Governor · integrated ECI · President's power over reserved State bills.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Unitary features (the 14) — high-yield

HIGH

Foundation · Scholar tags (learn these!)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Match: **Wheare → "quasi-federal" · Morris Jones → "bargaining federalism"** ·

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

SCHOLAR TAGS (LEARN THESE!): RECALL MAP

Scholar tags (learn these!)

V

Dimension 1 Match: Wheare → "quasi-federal" · Morris Jones → "bargaining federalism" ·	**Dimension 2** Jennings → "centralising tendency" · Alexandrowicz → "sui generis" ·
Dimension 3 Granville Austin → "cooperative federalism" · Paul Appleby → "extremely federal".	

STATIC THEORY

- Jennings → "centralising tendency" · Alexandrowicz → "sui generis" ·

- Granville Austin → "cooperative federalism" · Paul Appleby → "extremely federal".

MEMORY HOOK

Match: Wheare → "quasi-federal" · Morris Jones → "bargaining federalism" ·

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Scholar tags (learn these!)

HIGH

Foundation · Must-Know Facts

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ India = "indestructible Union of **destructible states**"; USA = "…of indestructible states".

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS: RECALL MAP

Must-Know Facts

V

Dimension 1 □ India = "indestructible Union of destructible states"; USA = "…of indestructible states".	**Dimension 2** □ Residuary powers → Centre (opposite of USA).
Dimension 3 □ S.R. Bommai (1994): federalism is a basic feature; states are not appendages.	**Dimension 4** □ Only exception to single Constitution was pre-2019 J&K.

STATIC THEORY

- □ **Residuary powers** → **Centre** (opposite of USA).
- □ **S.R. Bommai (1994):** federalism is a **basic feature**; states are **not appendages**.
- □ Only exception to single Constitution was **pre-2019 J&K**.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. India = "indestructible Union of **destructible states**"; USA = "…of indestructible states".

2. Residuary powers → **Centre** (opposite of USA).

3. S.R. Bommai (1994): federalism is a **basic feature**; states are **not appendages**.

4. Only exception to single Constitution was **pre-2019 J&K**.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Must-Know Facts

HIGH

Foundation · □ Current link

GS-II Indian Polity

NEWS TRIGGER

□ □□ GST coordination, fiscal-devolution demands and bill-assent disputes keep federalism live. For assent, use the controlling **20 Nov 2025 Article 143 opinion**: no rigid judicial timelines/deemed assent, but prolonged unexplained inaction is reviewable. □□ All 7 federal + 14 unitary features, the scholar tags and *Bommai* are held **in this file** (§8.4–§8.8). *Advanced: optional extended narrative in advanced/12_Federal-System.md — not required for any mark.* For India-USA-Canada-Australia-Germany-Switzerland federal and upper-house comparison, use Comparative-Constitutional-Schemes.md.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of □ Current link.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → □ Current link

HIGH

Foundation · Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support).

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

Purpose: make this Core file independently able to answer directive-sensitive GS-II questions on the nature of Indian federalism, its centralising design, the cooperation/competition/confrontation dynamic and asymmetric federalism — without opening Advanced.

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

HIGH

Foundation · 8.0 Direct Mains demands owned by this Core file

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of 8.0 Direct Mains demands owned by this Core file.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

2020 · GS-II · Q3 *— Demand (neutral rendering): how cooperation, competition and confrontation have shaped the Indian federation. Directive:* ***How far do you think*** *(extent/evaluation) ·* ***10 marks · 150 words****.* ***Core routing supersedes the older advanced/12_Federal-System.md pointer for this demand. Executable route:*** *(1)* ***Thesis*** *— Indian federalism is dynamic and bargaining (Morris-Jones), oscillating between the three modes by issue and political alignment; cooperation dominates institutionally while confrontation is rising. (2)* ***Cooperation*** *— GST Council (****Art 279A****), Inter-State Council (****Art 263****), Finance Commission transfers, disaster/pandemic coordination. (3)* ***Competition*** *— NITI Aayog indices (SDG India Index, Aspirational Districts), inter-State investment competition, Ease-of-Doing-Business rankings. (4)* ***Confrontation*** *— Governors' delay in assenting to Bills, withdrawal of "general consent" to the CBI, GST-compensation and cess/surcharge disputes, southern-State grievances over the devolution formula. (5)* ***Frame*** *— S.R. Bommai (1994): federalism is a basic feature, so conflict is bounded by constitutionalism. (6)* ***Verdict*** *— India is cooperative/bargaining federalism punctuated by episodic confrontation; its strength is institutional channels that absorb conflict.* ***2022 · GS-II · Q13*** *— Demand (neutral rendering): national parties favour centralisation while regional parties favour State autonomy. Directive:* ***Comment*** *·* ***15 marks · 250 words****. Shared with basic/Political-Parties.md;* ***this file owns the federal half*** *(the party-system half belongs there).* ***Core routing supersedes the older advanced/12_Federal-System.md pointer for this demand. Executable route (federal half):*** *(1)* ***Thesis*** *— the correlation is broadly valid but tracks incentives and position in the power structure, not party ideology, and reverses when a party moves between office and opposition. (2)* ***Centralising tools a Union-holding national party leans on*** *— the 14 Union-bias features: residuary power,* ***All-India Services****, Article 249, the centrally appointed Governor (Articles 155-156) and historically Article 356. (3)* ***Autonomy demands of regional parties*** *— fairer tax devolution, neutral gubernatorial conduct, fewer conditionalities in centrally sponsored schemes, Sarkaria/Punchhi reforms and regular Inter-State Council consultation. (4)* ***Counter-evidence*** *— the coalition era (1989–2014) saw national parties strengthen States; regional parties centralise within their own States; national parties demand autonomy where they sit in opposition. (5)* ***Verdict*** *— preference follows the incentive of who controls the Union; qualified agreement, not a law of party behaviour.*

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.0 Direct Mains demands owned by this Core file

HIGH

Foundation · 8.1 Demand and directive map

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Demand family	Typical directive signals	Answer spine to use
Nature of Indian federalism	"quasi-federal", "sui generis", "unitary with federal features", Evaluate	Federal features → unitary features → scholarly tags → *Bommai* → qualified label
Cooperation/competition/confrontation	"How far", "which best describes India", Discuss	Define three modes → named instances of each → dominant tendency → verdict
Centralisation vs autonomy	"national vs regional parties", "over-centralisation", Comment	Unitary tools → autonomy demands → coalition-era counter → position-not-ideology verdict
Fiscal / institutional federalism	"cooperative federalism", GST, devolution, Analyse	Art 279A/263 institutions → transfers → grievances → cooperative-but-contested verdict
Asymmetric federalism	"special provisions", Art 371, Fifth/Sixth Schedule, Examine	Definition → constitutional instances → rationale → tension with uniformity
Federalism as basic structure	"basic feature", *Bommai*, Critically examine	Pre-*Bommai* centralism → *Bommai* propositions → post-1994 practice → limits

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.1 Demand and directive map

HIGH

Foundation · 8.2 Qualified thesis options

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

India is best described not as "federal" or "unitary" but as a centralised federation whose balance shifts with circumstance — federal in form, unitary in emergency, cooperative in finance and confrontational at the political margins.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

8.2 QUALIFIED THESIS OPTIONS: RECALL MAP

8.2 Qualified thesis options

V

Dimension 1
India is best described not as "federal" or "unitary" but as a centralised federation whose balance shifts with circumstance — federal in form, unitar

Dimension 2
The cooperation–competition–confrontation triad is not a defect but the normal operating mode of a bargaining federation; Indian federalism works by c

Dimension 3
Party preferences on centralisation track the incentive of who holds the Union, not party ideology, which is why the same party centralises in office

Dimension 4
Since S.R. Bommai (1994), federalism is a basic feature, so centralisation now operates within a judicially enforced floor of State autonomy rather th

STATIC THEORY

- The cooperation–competition–confrontation triad is not a defect but the normal operating mode of a bargaining federation; Indian federalism works by channelling conflict through institutions, not by eliminating it.

- Party preferences on centralisation track the incentive of who holds the Union, not party ideology, which is why the same party centralises in office and demands autonomy in opposition.

- Since S.R. Bommai *(1994), federalism is a basic feature, so centralisation now operates within a judicially enforced floor of State autonomy rather than at the Centre's untrammelled discretion.*

- Asymmetric federalism is India's constitutional answer to diversity: uniform citizenship coexists with graduated autonomy, which strengthens rather than weakens the Union.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ 8.2 Qualified thesis options

HIGH

Foundation · 8.3 Mark-scaled structures

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Marks	Architecture	Evidence load
10	Thesis → two modes/features → one qualification → verdict	3 units, at least one Article + one scholar/case
15	Thesis → federal vs unitary features → scholarly frame → named instances → qualified verdict	5–6 units
20	Thesis → federal features → unitary features → scholarly debate → case law → three modes with instances → asymmetry → graded verdict	6–8 units + a "which label fits" paragraph

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ 8.3 Mark-scaled structures

HIGH

Foundation · 8.4 Bank A — Federal vs unitary features on the exact Articles

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Direction	Feature	Article/anchor	Analytical point
□ Federal	Division of powers	**Seventh Schedule** — standard counts: Union List (**100**), State List (**61**), Concurrent List (**52**)	Powers divided by the Constitution itself; **residuary → Centre** (opposite of the USA); retained omitted/inserted numbering explains alternate literal counts
□ Federal	Supremacy & rigidity	**Art 368** — federal provisions need a special majority **plus ratification by half the States**	Neither level can unilaterally rewrite the federal bargain
□ Federal	Independent judiciary; bicameralism	**Art 131** original jurisdiction; **Art 80** Rajya Sabha	SC settles Centre–State disputes; RS represents the States
□ Unitary	Strong Centre & destructible States	**Art 3** — Parliament alters area/boundary/name by simple majority	"Indestructible Union of **destructible States**"
□ Unitary	Parliament over the State List	**Art 249** (RS resolution, national interest); also **Art 250, 252, 253, 356**	Centre can enter the State field without a formal emergency
□ Union bias	Centrally appointed Governor	**Arts 155-156** — appointed by, holds office during the pleasure of the President	Potential channel of Union influence; constitutionally the Governor is the State's head, not a Union agent
□ Unitary	Emergency provisions; single citizenship; integrated judiciary, audit, ECI, All-India Services	**Art 352–360**, **Art 5–11**, **Art 148**, **Art 324**, **Art 312**	Convert the federal scheme toward unitary working **without amendment**

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.4 Bank A — Federal vs unitary features on the exact Articles

HIGH

Foundation · 8.4 Bank A — Federal vs unitary features on the exact Articles

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Analytical use: answer any "is India federal?" question by pairing the federal column against the unitary column and then invoking the scholarly label and *Bommai*.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.4 Bank A — Federal vs unitary features on the exact Articles

HIGH

Foundation · 8.4A Administrative and financial distribution — Core bridge

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Cluster	Provisions	Exam-safe rule
Compliance and directions	**Arts 256-257**	State administration must comply with applicable parliamentary law and not impede Union power; directions are constitutionally bounded, not a general takeover
Reciprocal delegation	**Arts 258-258A**	Union functions may be entrusted to States with consent, and State functions to the Union with consent; legislative ownership does not automatically move
Legal unity and consultation	**Arts 261-263**	Full faith and credit; Parliament may create water-dispute adjudication and exclude jurisdiction by law; the President may establish a recommendatory Inter-State Council
Union duty and emergency remedy	**Arts 355-357**	Article 355 is a duty; Article 356 requires constitutional breakdown and remains reviewable under *Bommai*; Article 357 concerns legislative power during the proclamation
Revenue and grants	**Arts 268-281**	Assignment, divisible-pool distribution, grants, GST apportionment and Finance Commission recommendations structure fiscal interdependence
State borrowing	**Art 293**	Union consent may be required where the specified Union debt condition applies

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.4A Administrative and financial distribution — Core bridge

HIGH

Foundation · 8.4A Administrative and financial distribution — Core bridge

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Core line: legislative autonomy needs administrative machinery and predictable fiscal

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

8.4A ADMINISTRATIVE AND FINANCIAL DISTRIBUTION — CORE BRIDGE: RECALL MAP

8.4A Administrative and financial distribution — Core bridge

V

Dimension 1 Core line: legislative autonomy needs administrative machinery and predictable fiscal	**Dimension 2** capacity; Indian federalism distributes all three, while creating coordination routes between
Dimension 3 them.	

STATIC THEORY

- capacity; Indian federalism distributes all three, while creating coordination routes between

- them.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.4A Administrative and financial distribution — Core bridge

HIGH

Foundation · 8.5 Bank B — Scholarly characterisations (the PYQ-favourite tags)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Scholar	Characterisation	Use it to argue
□ **K.C. Wheare**	**"Quasi-federal"** — a unitary state with subsidiary federal features	Centralising thesis
□ **Granville Austin**	**"Cooperative federalism"** — "a new kind of federation to meet India's needs"	Cooperation thesis
□ **Ivor Jennings**	**"Federation with a strong centralising tendency"**	Centralisation thesis
□ **Morris-Jones**	**"Bargaining federalism"**	Cooperation–confrontation dynamic
□ **K. Santhanam**	Unitary bias from the Centre's financial dominance and the erstwhile Planning Commission	Fiscal-federal critique
□ **Paul Appleby**	**"Extremely federal"**	Counter to the over-centralisation charge
□ **Alexandrowicz**	**"Sui generis"** (unique)	India-does-not-fit-the-template thesis
□ **B.R. Ambedkar**	The Constitution "can be **both unitary and federal** according to the requirements of time and circumstances"	Flexibility/dynamic thesis

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.5 Bank B — Scholarly characterisations (the PYQ-favourite tags)

HIGH

Foundation · 8.6 Bank C — The three modes with named Indian instances

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Mode	What it means	Named Indian instances
□/□□ **Cooperative**	Centre and States act through joint institutions	**GST Council (Art 279A)**, **Inter-State Council (Art 263)**, Finance Commission transfers, disaster/pandemic coordination, Zonal Councils
□/□□ **Competitive**	States compete for capital and performance	NITI Aayog's **SDG India Index** and **Aspirational Districts Programme**, inter-State investment competition, ranking-driven reform
□/□□ **Confrontational / coercive**	Institutional friction and central pressure	Governors' delay in assenting to Bills, withdrawal of **"general consent" to the CBI** under the DSPE Act, **GST-compensation and cess/surcharge** disputes, southern-State grievances over the devolution formula, inter-State river-water disputes (e.g., Cauvery)

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.6 Bank C — The three modes with named Indian instances

HIGH

Foundation · 8.6 Bank C — The three modes with named Indian instances

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Balance rule: □□ the three modes coexist rather than succeed one another; the strongest answers name at least one instance of each and then judge which dominates.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.6 Bank C — The three modes with named Indian instances

HIGH

Foundation · 8.7 Bank D — Asymmetric federalism

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Definition: □ different States/units enjoy **different degrees of autonomy** within one Union — India's constitutional response to diversity.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

8.7 BANK D — ASYMMETRIC FEDERALISM: RECALL MAP

8.7 Bank D — Asymmetric federalism

V

Dimension 1 Definition: □ different States/units enjoy different degrees of autonomy within one Union — India's constitutional response to diversity.	**Dimension 2** Constitutional instances: □ the Art 371 to 371-J special provisions (e.g., 371A Nagaland, 371G Mizoram, 371D–F Andhra/Telangana and Sikkim), the Fifth
Dimension 3 Status caution: □ Art 370 (special status for J&K) was rendered inoperative in 2019 and J&K reorganised into two Union Territories — do not cite it as	

STATIC THEORY

- **Constitutional instances:** □ the **Art 371 to 371-J** special provisions (e.g., 371A Nagaland, 371G Mizoram, 371D–F Andhra/Telangana and Sikkim), the **Fifth and Sixth Schedules** for tribal areas, **Art 239AA** for Delhi, and Union-Territory vs State asymmetry.

- **Status caution:** □ **Art 370** (special status for J&K) was rendered inoperative in **2019** and J&K reorganised into two Union Territories — do not cite it as live. □□ "**Special category status**" is an **administrative/Finance-Commission-era** concept, **not** a constitutional category.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Definition: different States/units enjoy **different degrees of autonomy** within one Union — India's constitutional response to diversity.

2. Constitutional instances: the **Art 371 to 371-J** special provisions (e.g., 371A Nagaland, 371G Mizoram, 371D–F Andhra/Telangana and Sikkim), the **Fifth and Sixth Schedules** for tribal areas, **Art 239AA** for Delhi, and Union-Territory vs State asymmetry.

3. Status caution: Art 370 (special status for J&K) was rendered inoperative in **2019** and J&K reorganised into two Union Territories — do not cite it as live. □□ "**Special category status**" is an **administrative/Finance-Commission-era** concept, **not** a constitutional category.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ 8.7 Bank D — Asymmetric federalism

HIGH

Foundation · 8.7A Bank D2 — Representational federalism: the seat freeze and the 2026 delimitation attempt

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Claim	Named provision / event	Mechanism / significance	Limitation / caution
The Lok Sabha is designed to track population, and India has **no equal-representation upper house to offset it**	**Art 81(2)(a)** (seat–population ratio uniform across States, so far as practicable); **Art 80** + **Fourth Schedule** allot Rajya Sabha seats by **population, not equally**	Unlike the US Senate or the Australian Senate, India's second chamber **amplifies** rather than corrects population weight — so representation is a **single-axis** federal question	Do not describe the Rajya Sabha as an "equal-representation" chamber; do not import US Senate logic into India
Population representation has been **frozen since 1976** as an explicit federal bargain	**42nd Amendment (1976)** froze allocation on the **1971 census**; **84th Amendment (2001)** extended the freeze to after the first census taken after **2026** while allowing boundary readjustment; **87th Amendment (2003)** shifted boundary readjustment to the **2001** census	The bargain: States that reduced fertility would not lose national political weight for having done so — a rare instance of the Constitution **paying for a policy outcome in seats**	The freeze is on **allocation between States**, not on redrawing boundaries within a State — keep the two apart
The freeze was tested and the attempt failed	**Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026** + **Delimitation Bill, 2026** + **UT Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026**, introduced **16 April 2026**; the **131st Amendment Bill** carried the **Art 81** ceiling change — **550** → **850** (up to **815** States + **35** UTs) — with the accompanying Bill using the latest published census; **negatived 17 April 2026, 298 : 230** of **528** present and voting — below two-thirds under **Art 368(2)**; the linked Bills were withdrawn	Shows that representational change requires a broad parliamentary bargain. Article 329(a) restricts ordinary judicial challenge to delimitation laws, while constitutional amendments remain subject to the Constitution's amendment framework	Defeated Bill. Cite **850** only as the **131st Amendment Bill's** text, never as law; **prohibited** — State-wise projections, projected women's-seat counts, any implementation year, or treating the defeat as precedent

Claim	Named provision / event	Mechanism / significance	Limitation / caution
□ The trigger census is now **scheduled**, so the question returns on a known timetable	□ **Census 2027** under the **Census Act, 1948** / **Census Rules, 1990**: **Houselisting & Housing Census 1 April – 30 September 2026** (each State/UT choosing a fixed **30-day** period inside the window); **Population Enumeration February 2027**, and **September 2026** for snow-bound areas; **reference dates 00:00 hrs 1 March 2027** generally and **00:00 hrs 1 October 2026** for snow-bound areas; India's **first fully digital census** with self-enumeration, and **caste enumeration** officially announced. □ Because the **106th Amendment commenced on 16 April 2026** (□□ commencement only — the reservation is **still not operational**), this is simultaneously the **"first census taken after 2026"** for the **84th Amendment / Art 82** freeze and the **"first census taken after the commencement"** for **Art 334A(1)**	One statutory exercise now carries **two** constitutional triggers — the end of the seat freeze and the switching-on of the women's quota. That is why representational federalism is no longer a hypothetical dispute: the fact that made it postponable is expiring	□□ **Notified conduct and reference dates are NOT the publication date of final figures**, and both Art 82 and Art 334A(1) turn on **publication**. **Prohibited:** any publication date, any delimitation date, any date/year/election for the women's reservation, any nationwide houselisting progress claim as on **13 August 2026** (the schedule is State/UT-specific, so no exact nationwide wording is safe), and any State-wise seat projection
The objection is structural, not merely regional politics	□□ States with strong demographic performance face a **compounding** loss: fewer relative Lok Sabha seats, a population-weighted Rajya Sabha, and **population as a criterion in the Finance Commission's horizontal formula** as well	Makes the point that representation and devolution are **the same argument in two currencies** — the strongest available 20-mark framing	□□ For the Finance Commission's criteria and their weights use Finance-Commission.md; do not quote weights from memory here
The counter-argument must be stated for balance	□□ Permanent malapportionment means a citizen of a populous State has **systematically less voting weight** than a citizen of a less populous one — a democratic-equality objection of the same constitutional rank as the federal one	Converts a one-sided "South vs North" narrative into a genuine **two-value conflict** (federal equity vs democratic equality), which is what "Critically examine" rewards	□□ Do not assign numbers to the disparity; argue the principle

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.7A Bank D2 — Representational federalism: the seat freeze and the 2026 delimitation attempt

HIGH

Foundation · 8.7A Bank D2 — Representational federalism: the seat freeze and the 2026 delimitation attempt

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Case	Precise proposition	Use / caution
□ **S.R. Bommai v. Union of India (1994)** (nine-judge Bench)	Federalism is a **basic feature**; "within the sphere allotted to them the States are supreme"; States are **not mere appendages**	The anchor for the autonomy floor; also made Art 356 judicially reviewable (see Emergency-Provisions.md)
□ **State of West Bengal v. Union of India (1963)**	The Indian Constitution is **not "traditionally federal"**; Parliament is competent to acquire property vested in a State (Coal Bearing Areas Act); States are **not sovereign** in the classical sense	Cite for the centralising/strong-Centre thesis; **Subba Rao J. dissented** for stronger State autonomy
□ **State of Rajasthan v. Union of India (1977)**	Gave a **broad, largely non-justiciable** reading of the President's satisfaction under **Art 356**	Marks the pre-*Bommai* high-water mark of central power; *Bommai* later narrowed it

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.7A Bank D2 — Representational federalism: the seat freeze and the 2026 delimitation attempt

HIGH

Foundation · 8.7A Bank D2 — Representational federalism: the seat freeze and the 2026 delimitation attempt

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□□ **Label first:** the 2026 package is a **defeated Bill** — evidence of a federal *argument*, never

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

8.7A BANK D2 — REPRESENTATIONAL FEDERALISM: THE SEAT FREEZE AND THE 2026 DELIMITATION ATTEMPT: RECALL MAP

8.7A Bank D2 — Representational federalism: the seat freeze and the 2026 delimitation attempt

V

Dimension 1 □□ Label first: the 2026 package is a defeated Bill — evidence of a federal argument, never	**Dimension 2** law, precedent or forecast. Full evidence unit: Parliament.md §7.4; the Art 368 arithmetic:
Dimension 3 Amendment-and-Basic-Structure.md §8.4.	**Dimension 4** Indian federalism is usually taught as legislative, administrative and fiscal. There is a fourth dimension the syllabus rewards and most answers miss:

STATIC THEORY

- law, precedent or forecast. Full evidence unit: Parliament.md §7.4; the Art 368 arithmetic:

- Amendment-and-Basic-Structure.md §8.4.

- Indian federalism is usually taught as **legislative, administrative and fiscal**. There is a fourth dimension the syllabus rewards and most answers miss: **how many seats each State holds in the House that makes and unmakes the Union government.**

- **Verdict scaffold (representational federalism):** □□ *"India's unresolved federal question is no longer only fiscal — it is representational. The 1976 freeze bought fifty years of peace by suspending the population rule; the 2026 attempt to end it was defeated on the Article 368 arithmetic, not on the merits, which means the question is postponed rather than settled. Any durable answer must pair reapportionment with a compensating federal safeguard, because India has no equal-representation second chamber to absorb the shock."*

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.7A Bank D2 — Representational federalism: the seat freeze and the 2026 delimitation attempt

HIGH

Foundation · 8.9 Criticism, counter-argument and variation

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Over-centralisation critique: □□ the 14 unitary features, the Centre's financial dominance (Santhanam) and the Governor's office let the Union crowd the State sphere; the **Sarkaria and Punchhi Commissions** recommended sparing use of Art 356 and Art 356/consultative federalism (developed in Centre-State-Relations.md).

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

8.9 CRITICISM, COUNTER-ARGUMENT AND VARIATION: RECALL MAP

8.9 Criticism, counter-argument and variation

V

Dimension 1 Over-centralisation critique: □□ the 14 unitary features, the Centre's financial dominance (Santhanam) and the Governor's office let the Union crowd t	**Dimension 2** Counter (federalism is resilient): □□ Bommai's basic-feature holding, the rise of coalition and regional politics, GST's shared decision-making, and F
Dimension 3 State/regional variation: □□ southern and eastern States press hardest on fiscal devolution and the Governor's role, while the direction of central pr	**Dimension 4** Implementation constraint: □□ cooperative institutions under-perform when under-convened — the Inter-State Council has met rarely, so cooperative fede

STATIC THEORY

- **Counter (federalism is resilient):** □□ *Bommai*'s basic-feature holding, the rise of coalition and regional politics, GST's shared decision-making, and Finance Commission devolution show a real bargaining space, not a facade.

- **State/regional variation:** □□ southern and eastern States press hardest on fiscal devolution and the Governor's role, while the direction of central pressure shifts with which party holds the Union — federal stress is **political-alignment-dependent**, not constant.

- **Implementation constraint:** □□ cooperative institutions under-perform when under-convened — the **Inter-State Council has met rarely**, so cooperative federalism is stronger on paper than in frequency of use.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.9 Criticism, counter-argument and variation

HIGH

Foundation · 8.10 Verdict scaffolds

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Nature verdict: "India is a centralised federation — quasi-federal in Wheare's form, cooperative in Austin's spirit, and *sui generis* in Alexandrowicz's judgement — best captured as bargaining federalism operating under a *Bommai* floor of State autonomy."

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

8.10 VERDICT SCAFFOLDS: RECALL MAP

8.10 Verdict scaffolds

V

Dimension 1 Nature verdict: "India is a centralised federation — quasi-federal in Wheare's form, cooperative in Austin's spirit, and sui generis in Alexandrowicz'	**Dimension 2** Three-modes verdict: "Cooperation, competition and confrontation are not phases but simultaneous registers; the health of Indian federalism lies in in
Dimension 3 Centralisation verdict: "Party preferences on centralisation are a function of who holds the Union, not of ideology, so the real safeguard of autonomy	

STATIC THEORY

- **Three-modes verdict:** "Cooperation, competition and confrontation are not phases but simultaneous registers; the health of Indian federalism lies in institutions strong enough to keep confrontation constitutional."

- **Centralisation verdict:** "Party preferences on centralisation are a function of who holds the Union, not of ideology, so the real safeguard of autonomy is institutional — the Finance Commission, the Inter-State Council and judicial review — not partisan intent."

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ 8.10 Verdict scaffolds

HIGH

Foundation · 8.11 Prelims close-option distinctions · Table 1.1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Confusion pair	Correct discrimination
"Federation" in the text	The word is **never used**; **Art 1 = "Union of States"**
Indian vs American model	India = **Canadian** model (strong Centre, "holding together"); USA = "coming together"
Residuary powers	Rest with the **Centre** in India (with the **States** in the USA)
Wheare's label	"**Quasi-federal**", not "federal"
Who coined "cooperative federalism"	**Granville Austin**, not Ambedkar
Rajya Sabha seats	By **population (1–31)**; only the **US Senate** gives equal seats
Bommai effect	**Affirmed** federalism as a basic feature; did not dilute it
Special category status	**Administrative** concept, **not** in the Constitution

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ 8.11 Prelims close-option distinctions

HIGH

Foundation · 8.11 Prelims close-option distinctions · Table 1.2

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Confusion pair	Correct discrimination
Essential federal feature	The **federal** features are dual polity, division of powers (7th Schedule), a written and rigid Constitution, supremacy of the Constitution, an independent judiciary and bicameralism
Prison administration	**Prisons** is a **State List** subject (Entry 4); the **Prisons Act, 1894** is administered by **State Governments**

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ 8.11 Prelims close-option distinctions

HIGH

Foundation · 8.12 Factual-risk and current-status controls · Part 1

GS-II Indian Polity

NEWS TRIGGER

 Art 1 says "Union of States"; do not claim the Constitution uses "Federation". Standard examination list counts: Union **100**, State **61**, Concurrent **52**; residuary power is with the **Centre**. Omitted and inserted entry numbers can produce different literal counts in the Schedule. Art 370 is **inoperative since 2019**; J&K is now Union Territory — do not present it as a live special-status State.

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Do not state exact bench strengths except where certain (*Bommai* = nine judges); do not convert a case's *obiter* into binding *ratio*.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

8.12 FACTUAL-RISK AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROLS: RECALL MAP

8.12 Factual-risk and current-status controls

V

Dimension 1 Do not state exact bench strengths except where certain (Bommai = nine judges); do not convert a case's obiter into binding ratio.	**Dimension 2** The three "modes" of federalism and the scholarly tags beyond Bommai are characterisations/analysis, not constitutional text — mark them accordingl
Dimension 3 On Governors and assent, use the controlling position: courts have declined to fix rigid timelines or "deemed assent", but prolonged unexplained ina	**Dimension 4** The Sixteenth Finance Commission submitted its report on 17 November 2025 for

STATIC THEORY

- □□ The three "modes" of federalism and the scholarly tags beyond *Bommai* are **characterisations/analysis**, not constitutional text — mark them accordingly.

- □ On Governors and assent, use the controlling position: courts have declined to fix rigid timelines or "deemed assent", but prolonged unexplained inaction is reviewable — verify the latest status before dating it.

- □ The Sixteenth Finance Commission submitted its report on **17 November 2025** for

- **2026-31** and retained **41%** vertical devolution; use exact horizontal weights only from the official report.

- □ Police and public order (**State List** Entries 1–2) and **prisons** (Entry 4) are **State subjects**; do not place them in the Union or Concurrent List.

- □□ **Representational federalism (§8.7A):** the **Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026**, the **Delimitation Bill, 2026** and the **UT Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026** are **defeated Bills**, not law. Permitted: introduction **16 Apr 2026**, defeat **17 Apr 2026** (**298 : 230** of **528** present and voting, short of the Art 368(2) two-thirds limb), the proposed ceiling **850 (up to 815 States + 35 UTs)** *as the text of the **131st Amendment Bill***, and the proposed **2011-census** basis — each as *the proposal's text*. **Prohibited:** State-wise seat projections, projected women's-seat counts, any implementation year, "delimitation will use the 2011 census", or treating the defeat as precedent. The **42nd/84th/87th** freeze chain and **Arts 81(2)(a), 82, 329(a)** remain the law.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Police and public order (**State List** Entries 1–2) and **prisons** (Entry 4) are **State subjects**; do not place them in the Union or Concurrent List.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.12 Factual-risk and current-status controls

HIGH

Foundation · 8.12 Factual-risk and current-status controls · Part 2

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□/□ **106th Amendment and Census 2027 (§8.7A):** the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023 **commenced on 16 April 2026** by notification under **s.1(2)** — the date may be written. □□ **Commenced ≠ operational:** the women's reservation is **still not in effect** pending the **Art 334A(1)** sequence. Permitted Census 2027 facts: **Houselisting 1 Apr – 30 Sep 2026** (State/UT-specific 30-day period), **Population Enumeration Feb 2027** (**Sep 2026** snow-bound), **reference dates 1 Mar 2027** / **1 Oct 2026** (snow-bound), **first fully digital census** with self-enumeration, **caste enumeration** announced. **Prohibited:** any publication date for the figures, any delimitation date, any effective date/year/election for the reservation, any nationwide houselisting status as on **13 Aug 2026**, and any seat projection. **Notified conduct/reference dates ≠ publication of final figures.** Full unit: Parliament.md §7.4.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- less than !-- BEGIN GENERATED PYQ INTEGRATION: 2018-2023 -→

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. /□ 106th Amendment and Census 2027 (§8.7A): the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023 **commenced on 16 April 2026** by notification under **s.1(2)** — the date may be written. □□ **Commenced ≠ operational:** the women's reservation is **still not in effect** pending the **Art 334A(1)** sequence. Permitted Census 2027 facts: **Houselisting 1 Apr – 30 Sep 2026** (State/UT-specific 30-day period), **Population Enumeration Feb 2027** (**Sep 2026** snow-bound), **reference dates 1 Mar 2027** / **1 Oct 2026** (snow-bound), **first fully digital census** with self-enumeration, **caste enumeration** announced. **Prohibited:** any publication date for the figures, any delimitation date, any effective date/year/election for the reservation, any nationwide houselisting status as on **13 Aug 2026**, and any seat projection. **Notified conduct/reference dates ≠ publication of final figures.** Full unit: Parliament.md §7.4.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → 8.12 Factual-risk and current-status controls

HIGH

Foundation · Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2021	GS-II	11	CBI jurisdiction, State consent and the federal character of India	Explain · 15 marks · 250 words	Cross-cutting ; investigative -agency source, federal consent and consolidated institutional classification	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2021	Prelims GS-I	86	Essential federal character feature of Indian polity	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2023	Prelims GS-I	32	Prison administration by State Governments Prisons Act 1894	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

HIGH

Foundation · Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023).

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

Status: *Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner.* ***Provenance:*** *Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2018-2023.md.* ***Answer-key rule:*** *The official 2018-2023 Prelims/CSAT keys are not held locally; no option or answer has been inferred.* ***Years represented:*** *2021, 2023* ***Paper(s):*** *GS-II, Prelims GS-I* ***Routed question demands:*** *3*

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

HIGH

Foundation · What this owner must now support

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

CBI jurisdiction, State consent and the federal character of India

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

WHAT THIS OWNER MUST NOW SUPPORT: RECALL MAP

What this owner must now support

V

Dimension 1 CBI jurisdiction, State consent and the federal character of India	**Dimension 2** Essential federal character feature of Indian polity
Dimension 3 Prison administration by State Governments Prisons Act 1894	**Dimension 4** The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not cl

STATIC THEORY

- Essential federal character feature of Indian polity

- Prison administration by State Governments Prisons Act 1894

- The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

- less than !-- END GENERATED PYQ INTEGRATION: 2018-2023 -⟶

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → What this owner must now support

HIGH

Foundation · Semantic-completeness ownership and PYQ control

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Semantic-completeness ownership and PYQ control.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

Federal test: *India combines dual polity, a written and supreme Constitution, distributed competence, partial rigidity, independent judicial review and bicameral representation. Article 1's 'Union of States' denies a compact-based right to secede; it does not erase the federal distribution.* ***Distribution:*** *Articles 245-246 and the Seventh Schedule allocate fields; Article 248 with Union List Entry 97 gives Parliament the residue. Article 246A is a special concurrent GST power, not a new Concurrent-List entry.* ***Union tilt:*** *Articles 3, 249, 250, 252, 253, 256-257, 312 and 352-356, the Governor's Union appointment, single citizenship, integrated services and emergency conversion explain why India is a holding-together federation with a strong Centre.* ***Basic structure:*** *Kesavananda Bharati supplies the limitation method and S.R. Bommai expressly treats federalism as a basic feature. Union strength cannot be converted into unlimited central supremacy over constitutionally assigned State fields.* ***Working modes:*** *cooperative, competitive and coercive federalism are analytical descriptions. GST Council, Finance Commission, Inter-State Council and Zonal Councils are different in source, membership and legal effect.* ***Asymmetry:*** *Articles 371-371J, Fifth/Sixth Schedule arrangements and Union territories show differentiated integration. Article 370 is inoperative and Jammu and Kashmir is not presently a special-status State.* ***Owned comparison:*** *the complete federal-unitary comparison belongs here: levels, source of powers, constitutional supremacy, amendment, judiciary, representation and territorial security. Topic 13 owns the detailed operating relations between the two levels.* ***Current assent law:*** *the 20 November 2025 Article 143 opinion rejects fixed judicial timelines and deemed assent, recognises Article 200 discretion, and permits limited mandamus only for prolonged, unexplained, indefinite inaction.* ***Fiscal and representational control:*** *the Sixteenth Finance Commission report for 2026-31 retains forty-one per cent vertical devolution. The 131st Amendment Bill, 2026 was defeated and its proposed 850-seat ceiling never became law.* ***Four-ledger/PYQ control:*** *the federal/unitary taxonomy, exact centralising devices, cases, commissions, current fiscal/assent/representation status and all routed demands were checked; direct and cross-topic ownership remain labelled.*

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Semantic-completeness ownership and PYQ control

HIGH

Advanced · Core Foundation

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Subject: Polity · **Tier:** Advanced (exam depth) · **GS Paper:** GS-II

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE FOUNDATION: RECALL MAP

Core Foundation

V

Dimension 1 Subject: Polity · Tier: Advanced (exam depth) · GS Paper: GS-II	**Dimension 2** Grounded in: Indian Polity by M. Laxmikant, Ch. 13 / "Federal System" (direct check of the local Sixth Revised Edition PDF).
Dimension 3 □ = from source book · □□ = inference · □ = current affairs.	**Dimension 4** Companion: basic/Federal-System.md.

STATIC THEORY

- **Grounded in:** Indian Polity by M. Laxmikant, Ch. 13 / "Federal System" (direct check of the local Sixth Revised Edition PDF).

- □ = from source book · □□ = inference · □ = current affairs.

- *Companion: basic/Federal-System.md.*

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. = from source book · □□ = inference · □ = current affairs.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Core Foundation

HIGH

Advanced · Federal vs unitary

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ **Unitary** = all powers in the national govt (regions derive authority from it) — Britain, France, Japan, China. **Federal** = powers **divided by the Constitution itself**; both levels operate independently — USA, Switzerland, Australia, Canada, Russia. □ "Federation" ← Latin **foedus** = "treaty/agreement". Units called states (US), cantons (Switzerland), provinces (Canada), republics (Russia).

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

FEDERAL VS UNITARY: RECALL MAP

Federal vs unitary

V

Dimension 1 □ Unitary = all powers in the national govt (regions derive authority from it) — Britain, France, Japan, China. Federal = powers divided by the Consti	**Dimension 2** □ Two ways to form a federation: (i) integration — weak states unite into a strong union (USA, oldest federation, 1787, "coming together"); (ii) disin
Dimension 3 □ India adopted federalism due to (i) large size and (ii) socio-cultural diversity — reconciling national unity with regional autonomy. □ "Federation"	

STATIC THEORY

- □ **Two ways to form a federation:** (i) **integration** — weak states unite into a strong union (**USA**, oldest federation, 1787, "coming together"); (ii) **disintegration** — a big unitary state grants autonomy to provinces (**Canada** 1867, "holding together"). □ **India followed the Canadian route** (disintegration → strong centre).

- □ India adopted federalism due to (i) **large size** and (ii) **socio-cultural diversity** — reconciling **national unity with regional autonomy**. □ **"Federation" is NEVER used** in the Constitution — Art 1 says **"Union of States"** (Ambedkar: not an agreement, no right to secede → indestructible). □ Indian model = **Canadian** (strong centre), not American: resemblance in (i) formation by disintegration, (ii) term "Union", (iii) centralising tendency.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Unitary = all powers in the national govt (regions derive authority from it) — Britain, France, Japan, China. **Federal** = powers **divided by the Constitution itself**; both levels operate independently — USA, Switzerland, Australia, Canada, Russia. "Federation" ← Latin **foedus** = "treaty/agreement". Units called states (US), cantons (Switzerland), provinces (Canada), republics (Russia).

2. Two ways to form a federation: (i) **integration** — weak states unite into a strong union (**USA**, oldest federation, 1787, "coming together"); (ii) **disintegration** — a big unitary state grants autonomy to provinces (**Canada** 1867, "holding together"). **India followed the Canadian route** (disintegration → strong centre).

3. India adopted federalism due to (i) **large size** and (ii) **socio-cultural diversity** — reconciling **national unity with regional autonomy**. **"Federation" is NEVER used** in the Constitution — Art 1 says **"Union of States"** (Ambedkar: not an agreement, no right to secede → indestructible). Indian model = **Canadian** (strong centre), not American: resemblance in (i) formation by disintegration, (ii) term "Union", (iii) centralising tendency.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Federal vs unitary

HIGH

Advanced · Federal features (7) □

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

#	Feature	Detail
□ 1	**Dual polity**	Union and States each exercise autonomous constitutional competence in assigned fields; neither State sovereignty nor secession follows
□ 2	**Written Constitution**	Lengthiest in world; defines structure/powers/limits of both levels
□ 3	**Division of powers**	7th Schedule — standard examination counts: **Union List (100), State List (61), Concurrent List (52)**; residuary → **Centre**. Omitted/inserted numbering explains alternate literal counts.
□ 4	**Supremacy of Constitution**	Highest law; laws violating it struck down via judicial review
□ 5	**Rigid Constitution**	Federal provisions need **special majority + ratification by half the states**
□ 6	**Independent judiciary**	SC guards Constitution + settles Centre-state/inter-state disputes
□ 7	**Bicameralism**	Rajya Sabha (states) + Lok Sabha (people); RS maintains federal equilibrium

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Federal features (7) □

HIGH

Advanced · Unitary features (14) □□ (very high-yield) · Table 1.1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

#	Feature	Key point
□ 1	**Strong Centre**	Union List longer + more important subjects; Centre overrides Concurrent; **residuary to Centre** (in US → states)
□ 2	**States not indestructible**	Parliament can alter area/boundary/name by **simple majority** → "indestructible Union of **destructible states**"
□ 3	**Single Constitution**	States can't frame own constitution (exception: pre-2019 J&K;)
□ 4	**Flexibility**	Bulk amendable unilaterally by Parliament; only Centre can initiate amendment (US → states can too)
□ 5	**No equal state representation**	Rajya Sabha seats by **population (1 to 31)**; US Senate = 2 per state
□ 6	**Emergency provisions**	National/state/financial — converts federal → unitary **without amendment**
□ 7	**Single citizenship**	Like Canada; no separate state citizenship
□ 8	**Integrated judiciary**	SC → HCs, one system enforcing both Central & state laws (US = double courts)

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Unitary features (14) □□ (very high-yield)

HIGH

Advanced · Unitary features (14) □□ (very high-yield) · Table 1.2

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

#	Feature	Key point
□ 9	**All-India Services**	IAS/IPS/IFS common to Centre & states, controlled by Centre — "violate federalism"
□ 10	**Integrated audit**	CAG audits states too; appointed/removed by President without consulting states
□ 11	**Parliament's authority over State List**	Art 249 — RS resolution lets Parliament legislate on State List in national interest (no emergency needed)
□ 12	**Appointment of Governor**	Appointed by President and holds office during presidential pleasure; this can create Union influence, but the Governor is constitutionally the State's head, not the Centre's agent
□ 13	**Integrated election machinery**	ECI runs Central & state elections; states have no say
□ 14	**Reserved State bills**	Under Articles 200-201 the Governor may reserve a Bill and the President may assent or withhold assent; non-Money Bills may be directed back for reconsideration, without importing the Union-bill veto taxonomy mechanically

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Unitary features (14) □□ (very high-yield)

HIGH

Advanced · Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

Scholar	Characterisation
□ **K.C. Wheare**	**"Quasi-federal"** — "unitary state with subsidiary federal features"
□ **K. Santhanam**	**Unitary bias** from (i) Centre's financial dominance, (ii) erstwhile Planning Commission
□ **Paul Appleby**	**"Extremely federal"**
□ **Morris Jones**	**"Bargaining federalism"**
□ **Ivor Jennings**	**"Federation with a strong centralising tendency"**
□ **Alexandrowicz**	**"Sui generis"** (unique)
□ **Granville Austin**	**"Cooperative federalism"** — "a new kind of federation for India's needs"

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite)

HIGH

Advanced · Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite).

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

□ ***Ambedkar:*** *Constitution is federal (dual polity; both derive authority from the Constitution) but "can be **both unitary and federal** according to the requirements of time and circumstances."* □ ***S.R. Bommai v. UoI (1994):*** *Constitution is **federal** and federalism is a **basic feature**; states are **not mere appendages** — "within the sphere allotted to them, the states are supreme."* □ *Indian federalism = compromise between (i) normal division of powers (state autonomy) & (ii) national integrity + strong Union in exceptional circumstances.*

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite)

HIGH

Advanced · UPSC Traps

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of UPSC Traps.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The word "Federation" appears in the Constitution

CORRECT: never; Art 1 uses **"Union of States"**.

WRONG: India follows the American federal model

CORRECT: Canadian model (strong centre, disintegration, "Union").

WRONG: Residuary powers rest with states

CORRECT: with the **Centre** (opposite of US).

WRONG: Wheare called India "federal"

CORRECT: "quasi-federal".

WRONG: Cooperative federalism was coined by Ambedkar

CORRECT: by **Granville Austin**.

WRONG: Rajya Sabha gives equal seats to states

CORRECT: by **population (1–31)**; only the US Senate is equal.

WRONG: Bommai diluted federalism

CORRECT: it **affirmed** federalism as a **basic feature**.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ UPSC Traps

HIGH

Advanced · □ CA hooks

GS-II Indian Polity

NEWS TRIGGER

□ □□ Live federal frictions: GST coordination, **Governor's delay in assenting to bills** (read with the 20 Nov 2025 Article 143 opinion), **NEET/education (Concurrent List)**, river-water disputes (Cauvery), and **fiscal-devolution** demands from southern states — all illustrate "bargaining"/ "cooperative" federalism in action.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of □ CA hooks.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ □ CA hooks

HIGH

Advanced · Mains angles

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Mains angles.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

"Indian federalism is a case sui generis." Discuss with recent Centre-state frictions. Cooperative vs competitive vs coercive federalism — which best describes India today? Do the 14 unitary features make India a "unitary state with federal features"? Evaluate post-Bommai. less than !-- BEGIN GENERATED PYQ INTEGRATION: 2018-2023 -->

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Mains angles

HIGH

Advanced · Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2020	GS-II	3	Cooperation competition and confrontation shaping Indian federation	How far do you think · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	13	National parties favouring centralisation and regional parties State autonomy	Comment · 15 marks · 250 words	Cross-cutting ; party system and federal balance both named in the stem	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

HIGH

Advanced · Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023).

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

Status: *Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner.* ***Provenance:*** *Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.* ***Years represented:*** *2020, 2022* ***Paper(s):*** *GS-II* ***Routed question demands:*** *2*

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

HIGH

Advanced · What this owner must now support

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Cooperation competition and confrontation shaping Indian federation

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

WHAT THIS OWNER MUST NOW SUPPORT: RECALL MAP

What this owner must now support

V

Dimension 1 Cooperation competition and confrontation shaping Indian federation	**Dimension 2** National parties favouring centralisation and regional parties State autonomy
Dimension 3 The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not cl	**Dimension 4** less than !-- END GENERATED PYQ INTEGRATION: 2018-2023 -→

STATIC THEORY

- National parties favouring centralisation and regional parties State autonomy

- The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

- less than !-- END GENERATED PYQ INTEGRATION: 2018-2023 -→

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE → What this owner must now support

End of Register Notes - UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI